

Chapter 156-1

What Liang Shi could be certain of was that she had never left a good impression on Lu Jiayi.

The first time they met was at the entrance of the art museum, where she almost got into a fight with Qin Lishuang.

The second time was at the Qin family banquet. She had failed to save Xu Qingzhu then, and her appearance rushing to find Xu Qingzhu was rather disheveled.

Where exactly had she left a good impression on Lu Jiayi that warranted her praise?

Liang Shi felt it was probably Lu Jiayi saying this to please Xu Qingzhu.

In fact, Xu Qingzhu really was very happy.

She even wanted to invite Lu Jiayi when they went to eat together.

Lu Jiayi was tactful and waved at them. "President Xu, you go eat with your wife. I'll just find somewhere to eat on my own."

"Wishing you a pleasant evening," Lu Jiayi said.

Liang Shi also waved at her and didn't forget to give her recommendations. "The army-style hot pot around the corner is quite good, and so is the Japanese restaurant next door."

Lu Jiayi nodded. "Got it, thank you."

Very polite.

She always wore a proper smile on her face. One could tell at a glance she was a person of great refinement, not some uneducated nouveau riche.

It was precisely because of this that one couldn't bring themselves to dislike her.

And it also made one feel a particular sense of crisis.

At this moment, the moon hung high, and stars were scattered finely across the black night sky like sprinkled diamond fragments.

The streetlights were all lit, enveloping the entire city in a layer of gentle light.

Liang Shi held Xu Qingzhu's hand as they walked along the road. Several times, she caught herself spacing out.

The two chose to eat Hunan cuisine.^1^

When they arrived at the restaurant, Liang Shi sat across from Xu Qingzhu and only then saw her eyes.

The dark circles under her eyes were very heavy—so dark that even foundation couldn't cover them.

Seeing Liang Shi looking over, Xu Qingzhu reached up with both hands to cover her face.
"What?"

Liang Shi reached out to wipe the foundation under her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu leaned back. "We're in public."

Liang Shi asked: "Have you not been sleeping well lately?"

"Yeah." Xu Qingzhu sighed. "I've been busy with a new project lately. It turns out Lu Jiayi is from the Lu family of the capital. I heard my grandfather mention them before. Her grandfather and my grandfather apparently had quite a good relationship, so we're preparing to collaborate."

While speaking, Xu Qingzhu lowered her head to unwrap the chopsticks, avoiding Liang Shi's piercing gaze.

But after being together for so long, how could she not notice these details?

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "So... is Lu Jiayi good?"

"In what way?" Xu Qingzhu handed her the chopsticks, then smiled. "As a business partner, she's indeed impeccable. Her work ability is frighteningly strong. Look at my dark circles..."

Xu Qingzhu said this, then immediately covered her eyes again. "Forget it, you'd better not look. It's too ugly."

"It's all her fault." Xu Qingzhu said: "Even when I was in school, I never experienced this feeling. She's really... such an overachiever."²

"For example?" Liang Shi asked gently.

"A proposal I thought would take two days to finish, she can complete in three hours." Xu Qingzhu said: "Working with her requires particularly high concentration and particularly strong ability to stay up late."

It had been so long since they'd seen each other, and Xu Qingzhu seemed even more animated than before, talking endlessly about work matters.

What she talked about the most was still Lu Jiayi.

The name Lu Jiayi appeared frequently at a rate of once every three minutes.

"She's like someone training an eagle through sleep deprivation."³ Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "She worked my assistant until she got sick."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I thought Teacher Xu was already overachieving enough." Liang Shi laughed lightly. "Didn't expect there'd be someone even more intense than Teacher Xu."

"Then you really should interact with Lu Jiayi sometime." Xu Qingzhu sighed.

One could tell that during these few days of working with Lu Jiayi, Xu Qingzhu was quite happy.

At least collaborating with Lu Jiayi was a pleasant thing.

No one would dislike a partner who was highly efficient and full of passion for work.

This was also why Xu Qingzhu was full of praise for Lu Jiayi.

It's just that hearing these words, Liang Shi felt rather uncomfortable.

Her mood was somewhat low.

There weren't many people in the restaurant, and the server quickly brought out the dishes.

Xu Qingzhu noticed her low spirits and tentatively asked: "Are you unhappy?"

Liang Shi answered instinctively: "Huh? Not really."

Even she herself sounded uncertain.

Xu Qingzhu then became certain. "Is it because I keep bringing up Lu Jiayi?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Silence was the best answer.

The two of them sat across from each other at the table, with steam rising from the hot dishes between them.

Clearly less than a meter apart, yet it felt like the Milky Way separated them.

It gave one a dreamlike, surreal feeling.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, then suddenly smiled lightly: "Jealous?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, then nodded.

She could see the caution beneath Xu Qingzhu's smile, so she picked up some bright red spicy dish for her and said with a smile: "Teacher Xu is so beautiful and has such strong work ability. Of course many people would like you."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu was momentarily stunned. Resting her chin on her hand, she looked intently at Liang Shi: "Does that include you?"

Liang Shi nodded with certainty: "Very much so."

Xu Qingzhu's smile spread from the corners of her eyes, gentle and beautiful.

But Liang Shi saw an unfamiliar smile on her—a smile that was being forced.

It looked calm and composed, yet seemed to be missing something compared to before.

Liang Shi finished the meal absent-mindedly. When they were about to leave the restaurant, she saw Xu Qingzhu lowering her head to rub her eyes, and suddenly understood.

Xu Qingzhu was too exhausted, lacking her previous vitality.

Whether teasing or bantering, she was forcing herself to do it.

It wasn't the same as how she was in front of Lu Jiayi.

In front of Lu Jiayi, she was relaxed, carefree, without lingering affection and without anything to hide.

But in front of Liang Shi, she kept hiding things, afraid Liang Shi would discover her vulnerability, her dishevelment, her discomfort. So it was like she was wearing a mask.

She was walking on a knife's edge, trying to give the impression of being at ease, yet her acting skills weren't quite up to par.

It was probably the torment of the nightmares that came every day, plus the development of new business. She was like a component placed on a gear, spinning at high speed without a moment's rest.

Yet after seeing Liang Shi, she still had to wear a smile, say nice things, and tease and joke like before to liven up the atmosphere.

Because Liang Shi was too reserved.

Liang Shi habitually hid all her words away, hid her true self away.

So Xu Qingzhu had to be the one taking initiative.

But in front of Lu Jiayi, she didn't need to.

Because there was no need to pretend, she could chat and laugh easily. Even when exhausted, her eyes would sparkle when talking about work.

Liang Shi's heart sank to the bottom of the sea in an instant.

There were no scenes for her tomorrow morning, so she could go home tonight.

Footnotes:

1. Hunan cuisine (湘菜): One of the Eight Great Traditions of Chinese cuisine, originating from Hunan Province. It is known for its hot and spicy flavors, often using fresh chili peppers, garlic, and shallots.
2. "Overachiever" (卷): The Chinese term "卷" (juǎn) is internet slang derived from "内卷" (involution), referring to excessive competition and overwork culture. Someone who is "卷" works extremely hard, often to an unhealthy degree, setting high standards that pressure others to do the same.
3. "Training an eagle through sleep deprivation" (熬鹰): A traditional method of taming wild eagles by keeping them awake for extended periods until they submit to their trainer. Used metaphorically here to describe Lu Jiayi's intense work style that exhausts those around her.